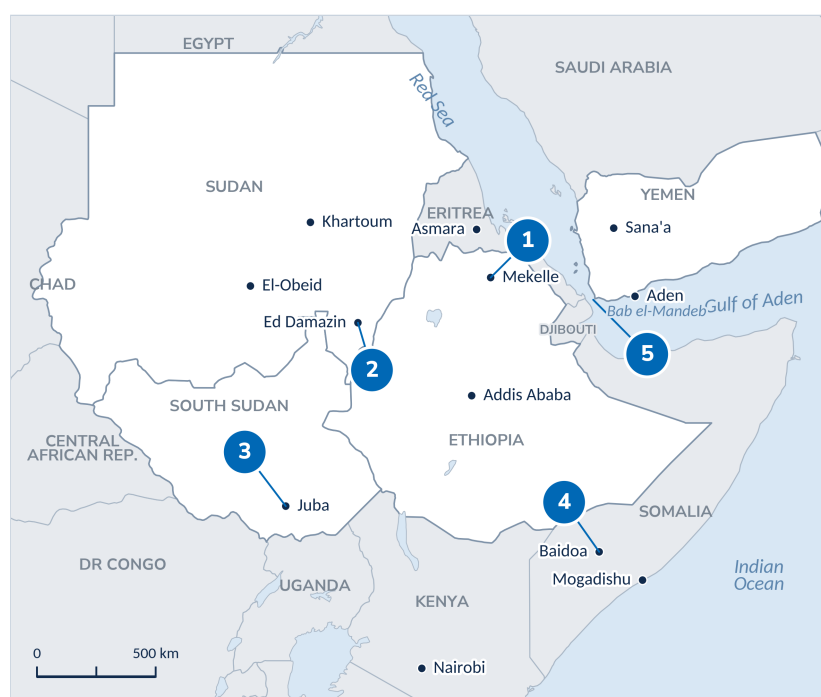


Nala Weekly

A weekly product of the Nala Center

In a single week, Ethiopian federal forces retook Mekelle and Addis Ababa broke off relations with Eritrea, as Egypt, Eritrea, Sudan and Somalia formalised an alignment at El Alamein that Ethiopia reads as hostile. Sudan's army chief rejected talks as the RSF pushed into Blue Nile, South Sudan headed for December polls without its main opposition, and Saudi-backed Yemeni forces fought the Houthis around Bab el-Mandeb.



Flashpoints covered in this issue. Map: Nala Center, using Natural Earth boundary data. Boundaries and names shown do not imply endorsement or acceptance by the Nala Center.

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1

Ethiopia

Key dates

1 October 2026

Ethiopia closes its embassy in Asmara; Eritrea cuts ties

3–4 October 2026

TPLF withdraws; federal and TPF forces enter Mekelle

4 October 2026

Drone strike on the Sheraro displacement camp

5 October 2026

Abiy Ahmed sworn in for a second term

Mekelle Falls, Eritrea Rift Widens

The war in northern Ethiopia turned sharply this week. After the Ethiopian National Defense Force (ENDF) and the allied Tigray Peace Force (TPF) counter-attacked in Afar on 1 October and advanced along the A2 highway through Korem, the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF) said late on 3 October that it had 'temporarily moved out' of Mekelle. Federal and TPF forces entered the regional capital and its airport on 3–4 October. TPLF chairman Debretsion Gebremichael has signalled a shift to 'mobile' fighting, and the rebel alliance has taken the war towards the capital: drones targeted military sites in Addis Ababa in the early hours of 1 October, an attack a rebel-linked source told Reuters was carried out by the Alliance for Survival.

Civilians are paying the price on both sides. A drone strike in the early hours of 4 October on the camp for displaced people at Sheraro, in north-western Tigray, killed eight people according to an aid worker cited by AFP, and nine according to *Addis Standard*; responsibility has not been established. *The Guardian* has reported witness accounts of TPLF-linked forces forcibly recruiting boys as young as 15, which the TPLF denies. Diplomatically, Ethiopia closed its embassy in Asmara and expelled Eritrean diplomats on 1 October, citing Eritrean acts of hostility; Eritrea responded by cutting ties, calling Ethiopia's support for its opponents and its sea-access ambitions a declaration of war. Addis Ababa also expelled an Egyptian diplomat, and Cairo reciprocated. Sworn in for a second term on 5 October, Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed restated that Ethiopia would secure an outlet to the sea.

Over the coming weeks to months, the conflict is likely to take one of the following paths:

- A** The TPLF withdraws to rural Tigray and wages a mobile insurgency while federal and TPF forces hold the towns and install a new interim administration, echoing the pattern after Mekelle first fell in November 2020.
- B** Federal forces push north towards Adigrat and the Eritrean border, and the diplomatic rupture escalates into direct Ethiopia–Eritrea hostilities, a risk analysts at Verisk Maplecroft have flagged.
- C** Mounting losses and external pressure bring the TPLF and the federal government to an AU-led humanitarian pause, although there was little sign of such pressure this week.

Recommendation

The AU Peace and Security Council and IGAD should treat the Ethiopia–Eritrea rupture as an interstate threat, revive the Pretoria Agreement monitoring mechanism and secure guarantees for humanitarian access and the protection of displacement sites, while the TPLF should end any recruitment of children.

2

Sudan

Key dates

1 October 2026

Burhan adviser warns the US truce plan risks partition

3–5 October 2026

RSF and SPLM-N attack Minza; over 5,500 displaced

5 October 2026

UN rights council extends Sudan fact-finding mission

6 October 2026

Burhan rules out talks with the RSF

No Talks, a New Front in Blue Nile

Sudan's army chief and Sovereign Council head, Abdel Fattah al-Burhan, ruled out negotiations with the Rapid Support Forces (RSF) on 6 October, telling a gathering in Merowe that the army would pursue military victory until the whole country is cleared of the rebellion. The statement came as a US proposal for a 90-day humanitarian ceasefire stalled. An adviser to Burhan told Reuters on 1 October that Washington appeared to be pushing a de facto, Libya-style partition, while the government says it has submitted comments on the plan rather than rejecting it. US envoy Massad Boulos and Burhan met in New Alamein on 4 October at a luncheon hosted by President Abdel Fattah el-Sisi, on the sidelines of an African Union coordination meeting.

The war is widening along the Ethiopian border. The army said on 3 October that it had repelled a joint assault by the RSF and the SPLM-North faction led by Abdelaziz al-Hilu on Minza in Blue Nile state, east of the Roseires Dam, and the International Organization for Migration (IOM) recorded more than 5,500 people displaced from villages in Wad al-Mahi locality over three days. In Kordofan, RSF drone strikes on a university dormitory and a displacement shelter in El-Obeid on 1 and 2 October killed at least ten people, according to the Sudan Doctors Network and AFP, and an aerial attack on 3 October hit two marked World Food Programme trucks in South Kordofan, killing a driver. On 5 October the UN Human Rights Council extended its fact-finding mission on Sudan for a year, by 28 votes to 10 with 9 abstentions, over the government's objection.

In the coming weeks, the conflict is likely to take the following trajectory:

- A** A war of attrition continues, with the RSF and SPLM-N keeping pressure on Blue Nile and drone strikes continuing around El-Obeid, while the 90-day truce remains unsigned.
- B** Blue Nile becomes a cross-border front linked to Ethiopia's war, as Addis Ababa and Khartoum, each accusing the other of backing its armed opponents, see their conflicts converge on the shared border.
- C** Egypt, as Burhan's host and a US partner, brokers amendments to the truce text, such as RSF withdrawal from cities, that the army can accept, opening the way to a conditional ceasefire.

Recommendation

The Quad (the United States, Egypt, Saudi Arabia and the UAE) and the AU should pursue localised humanitarian arrangements for the El-Obeid, Dilling and Kadugli supply routes, separate from the stalled nationwide truce, and all parties should end attacks on aid convoys and shelters for displaced people.

3

South Sudan

Key dates

24 September 2026

Kiir launches an inter-party dialogue in Juba

3 October 2026

SPLM-IO and Communist Party boycott reported

5 October 2026

Ruto hosts Kiir in Nairobi and urges dialogue

22 December 2026

General elections scheduled

Elections Without the Opposition

The inter-party dialogue President Salva Kiir launched in Juba on 24 September has stalled. The Sudan People's Liberation Movement-in-Opposition (SPLM-IO), led in Riek Machar's absence by acting chairman Oyet Nathaniel Pierino, and the Communist Party of South Sudan have stayed away, describing the process as controlled and funded by the government. Machar remains under house arrest and on trial with seven co-accused over the March 2025 attack on the Nasir garrison; he denies the charges. Some opposition forces will nonetheless contest the vote: the South Sudan Opposition Alliance (SSOA) faction led by former Vice-President Hussein Abdelbagi Akol said on 5 October that it would begin election activities.

Kiir has turned to regional partners for backing. Hosting him at State House in Nairobi on 5 October, Kenyan President William Ruto urged South Sudan's leaders to pursue dialogue and consensus and pledged support for electoral preparations; Kiir's office said the legal steps for the elections were complete and that logistical and financial preparations were under way. With less than three months to polling, the Nala Center could not find a published voter-registration timetable or a confirmed election budget as at 6 October, and rights defenders have reported restrictions on media and political activity. Upper Nile and Jonglei, which border Sudan's Blue Nile state and Ethiopia's Gambella region, remain the most volatile areas.

As the 22 December polls approach, the following trajectories are likely:

- A** An SPLM-dominated vote proceeds on schedule, with the Abdelbagi faction of the SSOA participating and the SPLM-IO boycotting, producing an election of limited legitimacy.
- B** Localised violence escalates in Upper Nile and Jonglei, particularly if a verdict in Machar's trial is delivered before polling day.
- C** Logistical or financial shortfalls force a short technical delay to the vote.

Recommendation

IGAD, the AU Committee of Five and Kenya should tie technical support for the elections to a credible inclusion track, including the Committee of Five's earlier call for Machar's release, while the government should publish a voter-registration timetable and lift restrictions on civic space.

4

Somalia

Key dates

30 September 2026

Bloomberg reports a planned Ethiopian troop withdrawal

4 October 2026

El Alamein declaration rejects Somaliland recognition

6 October 2026

Erdogan says spaceport construction has begun

31 December 2026

Current AUSSOM mandate ends

Caught Between Blocs

Ethiopia's war is reaching Somalia. Bloomberg reported on 30 September that Addis Ababa plans to withdraw more than 3,000 troops from Somalia to fight at home. A Somali defence official said Mogadishu had not been informed, and it is unclear whether the plan affects the 2,500 Ethiopian troops approved for the African Union Support and Stabilization Mission in Somalia (AUSSOM), Ethiopia's bilateral deployments or both. Most Ethiopian forces are based in South West State, where they help defend Baidoa against al-Shabaab. Any drawdown would come as AUSSOM's financing is in doubt: the United States has told the AU it will block the use of assessed contributions for the mission after 31 December.

On 4 October, President Hassan Sheikh Mohamud joined the leaders of Egypt, Eritrea and Sudan in the El Alamein Joint Declaration, which rejected any recognition of Somaliland, called for sustainable AUSSOM funding and declared Red Sea governance the exclusive responsibility of littoral states, a position Ethiopia rejects. Hassan Sheikh nonetheless congratulated Abiy on his new term. On 6 October, President Recep Tayyip Erdogan said construction of a Turkish spaceport in Somalia had begun, without giving its location or timeline. In a 5 October analysis, Amani Africa warned that external security entanglements, together with contested constitutional amendments and a stalled electoral process, risk the geopolitical capture of Somali politics.

Over the coming months, Somalia is likely to face one of the following trajectories:

- A** Ethiopia partially withdraws from bilateral positions and al-Shabaab tests defences around Baidoa and in South West State, while plans for a larger Egyptian role in AUSSOM are slowed by funding gaps.
- B** Bloc polarisation deepens, with Mogadishu moving closer to the Cairo–Asmara axis while Somaliland and Puntland strengthen Gulf and Israeli ties, drawing the Red Sea conflict closer to Somali shores.
- C** The federal government, federal member states and opposition agree an inclusive electoral and constitutional pathway, the outcome Amani Africa argues is the only durable safeguard.

Recommendation

The AU, IGAD, the UN and the EU should support a Somali-led political settlement on elections, the constitution and agreed rules for foreign military access and port concessions, while Ethiopia and Somalia coordinate any troop drawdown through AUSSOM to avoid security vacuums.

5

Red Sea / Bab el-Mandeb

Key dates

4 October 2026

Houthis seize Turbah on the Taiz-Aden road

5 October 2026

Government launches Operation Yemen Dawn

5–6 October 2026

Houthis claim strikes on Saudi infrastructure

The Battle for Bab el-Mandeb

The contest for the southern Red Sea has become a two-way battle. On 4 October the Houthis seized Turbah, a town on the main road between Taiz and Aden, moving closer to encircling Taiz, Yemen's third-largest city. Early on 5 October, forces of the internationally recognised government launched Operation Yemen Dawn under Saudi-led coalition air cover; Yemeni officials said they had retaken Dhubab, just north of the strait, and the coalition said 100 aircraft had struck 324 Houthi targets. The Houthis deny losing ground and have claimed strikes on Saudi oil facilities, airports and bases. A regional official and a US official told AP that the United States is providing intelligence and planning support, and Euronews reported that Pakistan and Turkey have agreed to deploy troops to Saudi Arabia under a defence pact.

The human cost is rising: the World Health Organization recorded 685 new casualties over six days, with Taiz the heaviest front, and IOM reported on 5 October that displacement since the west coast escalation began in June had reached 184,000. For the Horn of Africa, the stakes are direct, as fighting on the Yemeni shore places Eritrea's coast, Djibouti and Somaliland's port of Berbera within reach of the conflict.

In the coming weeks, the battle for the strait is likely to follow one of these paths:

- A** A contested coastal seesaw, with government forces holding parts of Dhubab under coalition air cover while the Houthis press on Taiz, keeping the risk to shipping high.
- B** Regionalisation, as foreign deployments to Saudi Arabia and deeper US support prompt Houthi retaliation against Saudi Red Sea ports, with possible targeting of facilities on the African shore.
- C** Coalition pressure forces the Houthis off Mayun (Perim) Island, easing the threat to shipping through the strait.

Recommendation

The UN Special Envoy for Yemen and Gulf states should prioritise a humanitarian corridor for Taiz, and the Red Sea's littoral states, together with Ethiopia, should open a maritime security dialogue that addresses the commercial interests of landlocked neighbours.

The Bab el-Mandeb front

The Houthis seized Mayun (Perim) Island in September and took Turbah on 4 October. Yemeni government forces say they retook Dhubab on 5 October; the Houthis deny losing ground.

○ Locations named in this section

Map: Nala Center, using Natural Earth boundary data.



About the Nala Center

The Nala Center is a youth-led, nonpartisan policy and research think tank based in Nairobi, Kenya. More about its work is available at www.nalacenter.org.

About Nala Weekly

Nala Weekly is a weekly product of the Nala Center. Each issue offers concise analysis of key developments, the trajectories they are likely to take and, where relevant, recommendations for policymakers. The analysis in this issue reflects information available as at 6 October 2026. Scenarios describe plausible trajectories and are not predictions. Casualty figures and territorial claims attributed to parties to a conflict have not been independently verified.

Sources

This issue draws on reporting and analysis from AFP, Al Jazeera, AP, Bloomberg, Reuters, *The Guardian*, *Addis Standard*, *Africanews*, Radio Tamazuj, Sudan Tribune, *The EastAfrican*, Garowe Online, Hiiraan Online, Euronews, *The National*, Amani Africa, the Critical Threats Project, ACLED, Chatham House, IOM, WFP and WHO.

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